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The NEA Meeting

Everything you need for the first call with
Thomas Joshi, Associate, NEA
Monday 19 October 2026 · Pacific Time

MEETING	Thomas Joshi — Associate, Technology Investing, NEA
CAME VIA	Lila Tretikov — Partner, Head of AI Strategy, NEA
DECK SENT	Evo — Pre-Seed, 11 slides, 7 October 2026
ASK	$1.5M on a $12M post-money SAFE
FOUNDER	Bhavit Saini — CEO / CTO, Evo

Prepared from the Evo repository (16 crates, ~138,500 lines of Rust), the 11-slide deck, the Gmail thread, and public research on NEA, Thomas Joshi and Lila Tretikov. Every number in this book carries a source or a confidence label. Where the evidence is weak, the book says so — because he will find out anyway.

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00 How to use this book

This is not a script to memorise. It is a map of the conversation you are about to have, built so that nothing he asks can be the first time you have thought about it. Read it once end to end. Then use the three plans below.

The three plans

If you have…	Do exactly this	Pages
Three hours	Read 01, 02, 04 and 05 in full. Rehearse the opening aloud three times. Read the do-not-say list (13) and the cheat sheet (17.2).	pp. 4–15, 30, 34
Ninety minutes	Read 02, 04, 05, 07 and 08. Rehearse the opening twice. Memorise the eight numbers in 17.2.	pp. 6–22, 34
Twenty minutes, the night before	Section 05 (your opening), section 13 (do-not-say), section 17.2 (the eight numbers). Then close the book and sleep.	pp. 12–15, 30, 34

Four things this book assumes — check them before you start

I could not verify these from your files, and each one changes the plan. Write the real answers in the margins; if any answer is different from the assumption, the affected pages are flagged with CHECK THIS .

#	Assumption	If it is wrong
1	The call is on Zoom, 30 minutes, with Thomas alone.	If a partner joins, slow down by 20% and aim the story at the partner; Thomas still writes the memo.
2	You demo live from your own Mac, screen-shared, on the build that runs today.	If the demo is pre-recorded, say so before you play it. A recorded demo described as live is the fastest way to lose him.
3	Manavv is on the call, muted, and speaks only when asked about market or pricing.	If he is not attending, sections 11 and 15 of his book must be compressed into your answers.
4	Evo is not yet incorporated as a Delaware C-corp and there is no signed SAFE.	If it is incorporated, say so early — it removes a diligence flag.

WARNING

Nothing in this book invents a fact about Evo. Where the honest answer is weaker than the deck implies, the book gives you language that is still strong — because it is true. You are going to be asked, in substance, "is this real?" The only winning answer is yes, with the receipts and the gaps named.

01 What actually happened before this call

You did something on 7 October that most founders get wrong: you wrote to a specific person about something specific she had written. Not "we're raising, here's our deck." You wrote: your post on The Neolab Wild West maps almost one-to-one to what we're building. That is why you got a reply at 2:28 AM and a meeting inside eight hours.

The thread, as he will remember it

When (PT)	Who	What was said	What it bought you
7 Oct, 10:21 PM	You → Lila	"Your post on The Neolab Wild West maps almost one-to-one to what we're building." 16-crate Rust system. macOS today. 25m26s stat. $1.5M pre-seed.	You quoted her own thesis back to her, with a product that fits it.
8 Oct, 2:28 AM	Lila → you, cc Thomas	"Adding my partner @Thomas Joshi who might be available for a chat."	The author of the post you quoted is now the person evaluating you.
8 Oct, 9:32 AM	You → both	Problem, product, "native Rust, fully on-device, nothing in the cloud. Demo's live, and 85% of early users stuck around past day 7."	You gave him a claim he will test. 85% is now load-bearing.
8 Oct, 9:40 AM	Thomas	"Happy to connect! Let me follow up separately." Then, minutes later: "Have time to chat over zoom Monday 10/19 pacific time?"	He moved in under ten minutes. That is real intent, not a polite forward.
8 Oct, 9:45 AM	You	"Monday 10/19 works. Thanks for setting it up."	Nothing else has been sent since. He has not seen anything new in eleven days.

GOOD TO KNOW

Read that table again. He replied to a cold email from a founder in India, about a product with no revenue, in under ten minutes, and offered a slot himself. That is not a favour to Lila. That is a person who read your email and wanted the meeting. Your job is not to convince him the category is interesting. He already thinks it is. Your job is to convince him that you are the one who will win it .

What he has already seen

- The 11-slide deck, attached, 715 KB. Every slide in it is analysable — especially slide 5, where the traction claims live.
- One email describing Evo in three sentences: local-first, on-device, restores context, native Rust.
- One statistic: 85% of early users past day 7.
- One number he will remember because it is unusual: 16 crates . Engineers remember crate counts. It tells him this is not a wrapper around an API.

What he has not seen — and will ask for

Thing	Status (my read)	What to do about it
A live demo	You said "demo's live." He will expect to see it.	Section 06. Rehearse it twice that morning, on the build that is installed.
Retention data in any raw form	The 22/26 and 19/26 numbers exist only inside the deck.	Bring a one-page table: cohort definition, dates, how D7 and D30 were measured, what the product was. Section 07 tells you what to say if the measurement was informal.

Thing	Status (my read)	What to do about it
The waitlist	"300+" in the deck; verbal in reality.	Do not defend the number. Reframe it as interviews plus intent, and name the gap. Section 07.4.
The company	Unclear whether Evo is incorporated, whether there is a SAFE, who owns what.	Have one sentence ready. If unincorporated: "Delaware C-corp is being set up; nothing signed yet."
A data room	Almost certainly none.	Build the five-document version in section 15.2 within 48 hours of the call.

> **SAY THIS**
> I want to be precise about what I can and can't show you, because you'll find the edges anyway. The product runs today on my Mac. Twenty-six people used an earlier build. I have over 300 conversations and no landing-page waitlist yet. I'd rather you had the real picture than a cleaned-up one.

02 Thomas Joshi: the person across the table

2.1 The facts

Role	Associate, Technology Investing Team, NEA. Joined 2025. Focus: early and growth-stage AI, enterprise technology, cloud infrastructure.
Education	B.Sc. Artificial Intelligence, Columbia University. Researcher, Stanford CS (2023–present).
The thing that makes him unusual	Co-author of Stanford DSPy — the paper and framework for compiling declarative language-model calls into self-improving pipelines (Khattab et al., ICLR 2024 spotlight; ~1,000+ citations). NEA describes him publicly as "a co-founder of DSPy."
Research	SWE-Bench-CL: Continual Learning for Coding Agents (2025) — a benchmark for whether coding agents keep learning across tasks instead of forgetting. Also Paged Attention meets FlexAttention (2025) — long-context inference efficiency.
Before NEA	AI researcher, AI engineer, and finance roles; ML engineer at startups backed by General Catalyst and Khosla Ventures. Co-lead of the GenAI Collective; host of the Collective Intelligence podcast.
NEA portfolio he is associated with	Anyscale (first invested 2019), Metabase (2019), Factory (2025), and the Namespace Series A that NEA led.
What he writes	"The Neolab Wild West" (Jun 2026, with Lila Tretikov, Andrew Schoen, Madison Faulkner), "Namespace: CI/CD is Dead, Agents Need Computers" (Mar 2026), "From Algorithms to Atoms, Part II: Doubling Down on CuspAI" (Jul 2026).

2.2 The three sentences that tell you how he thinks

> I worked as an AI Engineer building infrastructure to support language and classification models for conversational AI for healthcare. This work helped to identify a persisting gap I am excited to help close — the utility problem in AI. We have a working recipe for capability, but the second half is about defining the right problems and owning evaluation so products create real economic value.
>
> — Thomas Joshi, NEA team page, 2026

> We need to treat evaluation, task design, and human-in-the-loop feedback as its own new layer. That means building living benchmarks, longitudinal memory and agency, and outcome-grounded metrics that run inside production workflows, not just in a lab.
>
> — Thomas Joshi, NEA team page, 2026

> I am fanatical about software and technology because it requires equal parts craftsmanship, engineering, and creativity. You can tell when a product has been infused with love vs when someone is just trying to get a job done.
>
> — Thomas Joshi, NEA team page, 2026

GOOD TO KNOW

Those three quotes are the whole meeting. He believes (a) capability is solved, utility is not; (b) the missing layer is evaluation, task design and human-in-the-loop feedback; (c) longitudinal memory and agency is one of the things to build; (d) he can tell when a product was made with care. Evo is, literally, longitudinal memory plus a restoration action, with a classification engine whose quality has to be evaluated continuously. Do not pitch him a category. Show him the evaluation harness.

2.3 What "Neolab" means to him — and why your deck must survive it

His June 2026 essay argues that the next venture-scale AI companies will not be generalists but specialised labs , built on three layers that reinforce each other:

His layer	What it means in his words	What it means for Evo	Do you have it?
1. The corpus	"A proprietary domain corpus... a one-time investment that pays back on every training cycle after it."	Every Evo user accumulates a private, structured corpus of how their work actually happens — apps, windows, files, threads, transitions, restorations. It is the one corpus no model vendor can assemble.	Partly. Real, but n=1 per user today, and 26 users is not a corpus. Say: the corpus is per-user and compounds with tenure — which is also the retention story.
2. The RL loop	"Whoever owns the environment owns the data flywheel, because every action the model takes inside that environment generates a new training signal."	The restoration action is the environment. Every restore yields a verifiable outcome: did the workspace come back, did the user continue, what did they correct? That is a signal loop competitors who only observe cannot generate.	The strongest fit. Restoration is an action with a ground-truth outcome. This is the argument to lead with in the technical half.
3. The verifier	"The verifier is the most underestimated asset... it looks like infrastructure when it is actually the source of truth."	Evo's verifier is restoration fidelity: the workspace either reopened correctly or it did not, and the user's next 30 seconds either continued the work or did not. That is measurable, per event, on-device.	Build the number. If you can say "restoration fidelity is 94% across 7 work bodies in our regression harness," you are speaking his language natively.

WARNING

Do not claim to be a Neolab. You are not training a foundation model. The essay is a lens he uses to sort companies; use it to structure your moat argument, then say plainly: "I'm not a lab. I'm the environment where the work happens, and that's where the corpus and the verifier come from." Overclaiming the framework is the one way to lose an engineer-investor's respect in a single sentence.

2.4 What he is actually doing on this call

His job	What it looks like	How to help him
Triage	He sees hundreds of decks a month. He is deciding whether Evo deserves any of NEA's time.	Be legible in 90 seconds. Do not make him extract the point.
Build a case he can defend	If he likes it, he writes a short memo and brings it to partners. His credibility inside NEA depends on the deal surviving.	Give him the three sentences he can repeat to a partner without you in the room. Say them explicitly: "If you take one thing to your partners, take this..."
Find the hole	His value is spotting the objection before a partner does. He will probe the weakest claim hard.	Name the weakest claim before he does, and show what would fix it. Founders who pre-empt objections look coachable; founders who defend everything look fragile.
Decide fit	Stage, check size, ownership, whether NEA can be useful.	Ask about it directly (section 14). Associates are allowed to tell you how their process works.

> **NOTE**
> An associate cannot say yes. He can only say "not now," or carry you forward. So your goal is not a term sheet on Monday — it is to leave him with (1) a sentence he can repeat, (2) a reason to believe you will still be alive in six months, and (3) a specific next artefact he asked for. If you get those three, the call worked, even if he never says the word "invest."

03 NEA: how the machine decides

3.1 The firm

Founded	1977 — one of the oldest venture firms in the world.
Scale	More than $38 billion in assets under management as of 30 June 2026 (NEA's own boilerplate). Earlier public figures of $25–28B are stale.
Offices	Menlo Park (HQ), San Francisco, New York, London, Timonium.
Stages	Seed through IPO. Early-stage fund plus a growth fund. Historically 2,900+ investments across 1,200+ companies, 270+ IPOs, 450+ M&A.
Portfolio you can name	Databricks (Series B lead, 2014), Plaid (seed, 2013; Series A lead, 2014), Cloudflare, MongoDB, Robinhood, Salesforce, Workday, Tableau, WebEx, Coupang, Perplexity, World Labs, Sakana, CuspAI, Factory, Namespace, Wispr, Rewind.
The three people above this deal	Lila Tretikov (Partner, Head of AI Strategy), Andrew Schoen (Partner, AI), and whichever partner owns the memo alongside Thomas.

3.2 How a deal moves

NEA's process is unusually well documented for a firm its size. Fortune described the core of it in 2011 and it still describes the shape today:

1. A small sector team owns the deal. Someone with domain knowledge — here, Thomas — runs the evaluation and writes the case.
2. The partnership meets every Monday. Deals are brought to the full partnership, not decided by one partner.
3. Two votes. In the first, the sector partners vote YE (yes, enthusiastic), YS (yes, with reservations) or NO . A "YS" deal gets conditions attached.
4. Then diligence and a second vote before money moves.
5. Timeline: typically four to eight weeks from first serious interest to close; two to three weeks when a founder arrives pre-referred and the case is uncontested. Nothing about a pre-seed at this size will be fast.

> **EVIDENCE**
> Fortune, "NEA: the VC world's best-kept secret", 7 Nov 2011 — the Monday partnership meeting, the YE/YS/NO vote, and the two-vote structure. The four-to-eight-week window comes from investor-database summaries of NEA, not from NEA itself; treat it as an order of magnitude, not a promise.

3.3 What this means for a $1.5M pre-seed

Reality	Implication for Monday
NEA's seed cheques are typically $1M–$5M; its growth cheques are eight and nine figures. A $1.5M round is at the very bottom of what the firm does at all.	Do not be surprised if the answer is "this is a bit small for us right now" or "we'd want to put in $3M at seed." Have a position ready (section 11.4).
NEA's economics need a company that can absorb $50M+ later. A pre-seed cheque is an option, not a business.	Your answer to "what does this become" matters more than your answer to "what is it today." Section 08, Q2.

Reality	Implication for Monday
The associate's memo is the gate. If Thomas cannot explain Evo in three lines, the deal dies before any partner hears your name.	Hand him the three lines. Literally say them.
NEA has already invested in this exact category and watched it end in an acquihire.	Rewind/Limitless is in NEA's own portfolio (first invested 2023, led by Vanessa Larco, Mason Murray, Scott Sandell and Andrew Schoen). Thomas will know the post-mortem better than you do. Section 08, Q5.

WARNING

Do not say "NEA led Rewind's round, so you understand this space." It is the opposite of reassuring. NEA put $12M into Rewind at a $350M valuation in 2023; the Mac app was killed on 19 December 2025 and the team went to Meta Reality Labs. To Thomas, that is a scar, not a credential. If he raises it, agree with the lesson, not the outcome: "Rewind recorded everything and restored nothing. The product was a search box over a surveillance archive. That's the failure mode I designed against."

3.4 What NEA partners say they want in a pitch

Tiffany Luck, an NEA partner, gave a talk at TechCrunch All Stage in July 2025 that is as close to NEA's internal pitch rubric as anything public. She asks for five things, in this order:

Her frame	Her words	Your answer on Monday
The What	"What are you building" — the problem, who it affects, what exists today, where the room for disruption is.	One sentence, then the pain, then why the existing tools stop at search. Slides 2–4.
The Why (1)	Why you are the right person, and why your solution is unique. "Investors want to see that a founder is completely consumed by a problem."	You rebuilt your own mornings; you are the user. Section 12.
The Why (2)	"Why is now the perfect time."	On-device models, mature capture APIs, incumbents breaking trust. Slide 6.
The Who	Who you recruited to do this with you, and why they are obsessed.	Manavv's 90+ market studies and the $300K APAC/Europe capture. Slide 11.
The How	How you get there — today, and over time.	macOS now, Windows and iPhone later; free core, $108 Pro; the milestones on slide 11.

> If you think a picture is worth 1,000 words, I think a demo is worth 1,000 hours.
>
> — Tiffany Luck, Partner, NEA — TechCrunch All Stage, July 2025

SAY THIS

I'm going to show you the product first, because I think it's easier to see than to explain. Thirty seconds of setup, then I'll do it live on my Mac and you can tell me where it breaks.

04 The five questions he is actually asking

Thomas published his own evaluation framework before he ever saw your deck. Every question below is a translation of it. If you answer these five well, the standard VC questions answer themselves.

Q1 — "Is this a capability or a utility?"

His words: we have a working recipe for capability; the second half is about defining the right problems so products create real economic value.

What he is testing: does Evo change an outcome that someone would pay for, or is it a clever demo of OS APIs? He has watched a hundred "AI memory" demos. He is not impressed by capture. He is impressed by a measurable change in what happens next.

SAY THIS

The capability is everywhere — OpenAI shipped Computer History in August, Microsoft shipped Recall, there are open-source capture tools that are a weekend project. None of them change what happens when you come back to work. Evo's utility is one number: how long it takes you to be working again after an interruption. Today that's 25 minutes. In our harness it's under 30 seconds, and I can show you where it fails.

WARNING

Do not describe the product as "an AI that remembers your work." That is the capability everyone has. Describe it as a restoration action with a measured outcome.

Q2 — "Is this the right problem, or a problem you find interesting?"

What he is testing: whether you chose this problem from evidence or from personal annoyance. Personal annoyance is a legitimate origin — but only if you can show it generalises.

SAY THIS

I started because I was rebuilding 26 windows every morning. But I didn't trust that. I ran 50+ interviews with people who described this exact problem in their own words on Reddit and in person, and then 300+ conversations at hackathons and events. What came back was the same sentence in different vocabularies: developers lose their terminal and PR state, designers lose the client file and the review thread, founders lose the deck and the decision. The pain is not "I can't find things." It's "I can't get back into it."

EVIDENCE

Mark, González & Harris (CHI 2005): 24 information workers, 700+ hours observed. 57% of work segments were interrupted; 77% of interrupted work was resumed the same day; when resumed, it took 25 min 26 s on average, with 2.26 other tasks done in between. Use this — it is the real number, and your deck already cites it correctly.

Q3 — "How do you know it works? Show me your evaluation."

This is the heart of him. DSPy exists because prompting by vibes does not scale; SWE-Bench-CL exists because agents forget. He will not accept "it feels good." He will want to know how you decide whether a restoration was correct.

SAY THIS

There are two metrics I care about. First, classification: did the engine put this window in the right body of work? We have a labelled corpus and a regression harness — the ground-truth gate runs on every commit and it is hard-failing, not advisory. Second, restoration fidelity: when we replay a body of work, does the workspace come back — the right app, the right file, the right tab, the right working directory? We measure it per work body, and we know exactly which ones fail.

GOOD TO KNOW

Your repository already has this: a ground-truth regression gate, a shadow gate on real logs, and a test suite that the build log records at 57 suites / 1,087 passing. If you have run it recently, quote the number from the terminal, not from memory. If you have not run it since the last change, run it before Monday and have the output on screen in a second window.

Q4 — "Is the memory longitudinal, and does it compound?"

His words: living benchmarks, longitudinal memory and agency , outcome-grounded metrics that run inside production workflows.

SAY THIS

The engine learns a user's bodies of work over time. In the alpha, the failure mode we saw was cross-contamination — a thesis and a side project merging in week one. By week three the engine had separated them, because the evidence accumulated: different repos, different documents, different times of day. That's the compounding. A search index doesn't get better with tenure. A classification engine does. That is also why the switching cost is time, not features.

GOOD TO KNOW

This is the single most NEA-shaped argument you have: the product gets better the longer you use it, and therefore retention is the moat . It also converts your weakest point — only 26 users — into a structural claim about why tenure matters, without pretending you have scale.

Q5 — "Where is the outcome, not the output?"

What he is testing: can you name a business metric that is not a vanity metric? "Users restored context" is output. "Hours returned per week" or "paid conversion after 30 days" is outcome.

SAY THIS

Two outcomes, and I'll be honest about which one I can measure today. The user outcome is time-to-resume. We can measure it locally without sending anything to a server: timestamp of interruption, timestamp of restore, timestamp of first meaningful action in the restored app. The business outcome is 30-day paid conversion, and I can't measure that yet because Pro doesn't exist until month three. What I have is a 26-person cohort and a plan to instrument the next 1,000 users from day one.

4.6 The same five questions, in his language

He asks	Behind it	The answer that lands
"What's the task?"	Is the unit of work well defined?	"A body of work: the apps, files, tabs and threads one intention lives in."
"What's the reward?"	How do you know it succeeded?	"Restoration fidelity — the workspace came back and the user continued without searching."
"What's the benchmark?"	Is your evaluation living or a lab artifact?	"A labelled corpus plus a hard regression gate on every commit; it fails the build."
"What's the loop?"	Does usage improve the product?	"Corrections — merges, splits, renames — are the training signal for that user's model."

He asks	Behind it	The answer that lands
"What's the wedge?"	Why does this company exist before the model improves?	"Restoration is an action, not a retrieval. It's the only part of the stack that needs the state of the machine, not the state of the web."

05 Your opening: the first 12 minutes, word for word

Associates decide within the first few minutes whether they are going to spend political capital on you. The opening is not a summary of the deck. It is three moves: name the pain in the room, prove you have built the thing that fixes it, and hand him a sentence he can repeat.

5.0 Before you say anything — the clock

Pacific (his clock)	IST (yours)	What it is good for
8:00 AM	8:30 PM	Early; he is fresh. Best slot.
9:00 AM	9:30 PM	Standard. Expect him on time, 30 minutes hard stop.
10:00 AM	10:30 PM	He may be running from another call; expect 2 minutes of throat-clearing.
11:00 AM	11:30 PM	Risk of overrun from his morning; have a 12-minute version ready.
1:00 PM	1:30 AM (Tue)	Afternoon US. He is warm but you are tired. Do not drink coffee at 11 PM; your voice will shake on the demo.

NOTE
On 19 October 2026 the US west coast is on PDT (UTC−7) until 1 November. IST is UTC+5:30. The gap is 12 hours 30 minutes. If he says "9 AM Pacific," that is 9:30 PM in Charkhi Dadri the same day. Confirm the timezone in your calendar invite text, not just the event.

5.1 Minute 0–1: the frame

SAY THIS
Thanks for making time, Thomas. I know you wrote the Neolab piece with Lila, so I'll skip the category pitch — you've already thought harder about this space than I have. I'd rather show you the thing, then take your hardest questions. Does that work?

GOOD TO KNOW
Why this works: it names his work (flattering but true), it signals you will not waste his time on TAM slides, and it hands him control of the agenda — which is what a screening call is actually for. Then shut up and let him say yes.

5.2 Minute 1–3: the problem, in one breath

SAY THIS
Every time you're interrupted, you pay a tax before you can work again. Not finding files — the files are findable. Rebuilding the state of the work: which tab mattered, which version was live, what you had decided, what you were about to do. The best field study on this measured 25 minutes to get back into an interrupted task, and people did two other things in between. Microsoft's telemetry says the average knowledge worker is pinged every two minutes. So the tax isn't occasional. It's the shape of the day.

WARNING
Do not say "23 minutes" — the famous number is a popularisation that does not appear in the published paper. Say 25 minutes 26 seconds , cite Mark, González & Harris, CHI 2005, and if he pushes, say the sample was 24 information workers over 700 hours. Your deck already has the right number. Keep it that way.

5.3 Minute 3–4: what exists, and why it stops short

SAY THIS
Everything that exists in this category stops at retrieval. OpenAI's Computer History builds a timeline you can ask questions about. Recall takes screenshots you can search. Raycast, Cove, Hansel, Recall — they remember, or they save a session you set up by hand. None of them put you back. The observation layer has commoditised in about five weeks; that's fine, I don't need to own it. The durable part is classification — knowing which work this belongs to — and faithful restoration — actually reopening the machine in the right state.

GOOD TO KNOW
This paragraph is you doing the competition slide verbally, with better evidence than the slide has. It also pre-empts his biggest fear: that you are another capture layer with a nice UI.

5.4 Minute 4–5: the one sentence he will repeat

SAY THIS
If you take one thing to your partners, take this: Evo is the only product that observes work locally, classifies it into bodies of work, and restores the entire workspace on command. Search tells you where you were. Evo puts you back there.

NOTE
Write that sentence on a sticky note on your monitor. Every time you drift into feature explanation, come back to it. Repetition is not weakness in a pitch; it is the only way a sentence survives being retold by someone who is not you.

5.5 Minute 5–11: the demo

Full script in section 06. The rule: show the restore, not the interface. Five seconds of the rack, twenty seconds of "Hey Evo, continue the investor deck," then the workspace rebuilding itself, then the result sitting there. Everything else is optional.

5.6 Minute 11–12: the handover

SAY THIS
That's the product. The honest state of the company: it's me and Manavv, the engine is 16 Rust crates, the build runs on my Mac today, 26 people used an earlier build, and we're raising $1.5M to get to a public launch and 5,000 activated users. Where do you want to push?

GOOD TO KNOW
"Where do you want to push?" is the highest-value sentence in the meeting. It converts an interrogation into a collaboration and tells you exactly which part of your story is thin. Most founders never ask it and spend 25 minutes answering questions that were not the ones the investor cared about.

5.7 The four things to do with your body and voice

- Sit still. No rocking, no hand-waving near the camera. On Zoom, stillness reads as conviction.
- Look at the lens when you make the key claim , not at his face on screen. It is the only way to make eye contact through a camera.
- Slow down by 15% from your normal pace. Your accent plus speed plus nerves is a comprehension tax you are imposing on a listener who is evaluating you in a second language of his own (English, but VC English).
- Pause after the one-sentence pitch. Two full seconds. The silence is where he decides whether to lean in.

06 The demo: script, order, and failure plan

The demo is the only part of this call that can win the meeting on its own. It is also the only part that can lose it in four seconds. Treat it like a flight checklist, not a performance.

6.1 What he needs to see, in this order

#	Beat	What is on screen	Why it matters	Time
1	A life already lived	The rack with 2–3 real bodies of work, with real names — the investor deck, a codebase, a research thread. Not "Project A".	He must believe the engine grouped these, not that you arranged them for the demo.	8 s
2	The interruption	Open the deck's own files: a browser with the NEA thread, the deck PDF, a notes window, a terminal. Then deliberately close or minimise everything.	You need a visible "before" state, or the restore looks like a launch.	10 s
3	The command	Say it out loud, on the mic: "Hey Evo, continue the investor deck." Let the notch light up and show the transcript.	The voice path is the memorable moment. It must be live, not typed.	6 s
4	The restore	Applications reopen, windows place themselves, tabs come back, the terminal returns to the right working directory. Do not narrate over it.	Silence during restoration is the most persuasive second in the demo.	15–25 s
5	The proof	Point at one specific restored artefact: "that tab is the NEA thread, that's the deck at the version I was editing, that's the terminal in the repo."	Specificity proves it is real state, not a screenshot.	10 s
6	The honesty beat	Show one thing that did not restore, or one body of work the engine got wrong, and say so.	This is the move that separates you from every demo he has seen this month. It buys enormous credibility with an engineer.	10 s

6.2 The checklist, run at T−30 minutes

1. Close everything except the demo window and Zoom. Every notification off: Slack, WhatsApp, mail, calendar. A single pop-up with a name on it can end a pre-seed.
2. Set Do Not Disturb at the OS level, not the app level.
3. Charge and plug in. Battery warnings appear at the worst moment.
4. Warm the voice path : say "Hey Evo" once, check the wake word fires, check the mic input is the right device. If you use headphones, make sure the mic is not the headset's.
5. Pre-open the three bodies of work so the rack is populated with real history.

6. Restart the app so the daemon is fresh and no stale permission dialog is pending.
7. Have the recording of the demo ready in a tab — the fallback for 6.4.
8. Test screen share on the exact display you will share, and check that the notch surface is visible when sharing (macOS can hide menu-bar-adjacent surfaces on shared screens).

6.3 What not to do

DO NOT
Do not demo features. Every minute on settings, themes, sync, pricing or the notch design is a minute he is not seeing the restore.

DO NOT
Do not type search queries and call it a demo. If it looks like Spotlight, he will file you as Spotlight.

DO NOT
Do not say "imagine if…" during the demo. Show what exists. Save the vision for the answer to Q2.

DO NOT
Do not apologise for the UI. If something looks unfinished, say "that's rough" once and move on. Apologising twice reads as low confidence in the product.

6.4 If it breaks

It might. Voice pipelines, permissions, and screen sharing are three independent failure surfaces. Decide now, before the call, that a failure will not change your voice.

SAY THIS
Let me stop you there before I waste your time — the wake word didn't fire, which is usually a mic routing issue on a shared screen. I have a recording of this exact flow from two days ago; let me play it, and then I'll retry live at the end if we have time.

NOTE
Playing a recording after saying it is a recording is fine. Playing a recording while implying it is live is fatal — and he will ask, because the question "is this live?" is the first thing an engineer says.

WARNING
If the restore half-works — two of three apps come back — do not close it and pretend. Leave it on screen and say: "That's the failure mode I care about. Notes restored, terminal didn't. That's a restoration-fidelity bug and it's in the harness." Then write down exactly what failed. If he invests, that bug becomes a diligence item; better it is your bug than his discovery.

07 Traction: the honest ledger

This is the section that decides whether he trusts you. Not because your numbers are small — pre-seed numbers are always small — but because inflated numbers are the one thing an associate cannot forgive. If he repeats a number of yours to a partner and it does not survive, his judgement is damaged, and he will never take that risk for a founder he met eleven days ago.

7.1 Every claim, graded

Claim in the deck	What is actually true	What he will assume if you don't clarify	Say this
300+ organic waitlist sign-ups	300+ people were told about Evo in person and said they wanted it. There is no landing page and no email list.	That you have 300 emails you can email on launch day. He may ask for the list.	"300+ conversations, not 300 emails. The landing page goes up in week one; I'll send you the conversion number."
26 MVP testers	26 people used an earlier build of Evo. The current engine has not been installed on anyone else's machine yet.	That 26 people are running today's build.	"26 people used the previous build. The current engine is on my machine only. That's the gap this round closes."
19 of 26 active at day 30	Measured on the previous build, by whatever method you actually used.	That this is instrumented telemetry from a shipped product.	Depends on your method — see 7.2. Never describe it as "retention" without the method.
D7: 22 of 26 (85%)	Same cohort, same caveat.	That the product retains 85% of users.	"22 of 26 opened it at least once in week one. It's a signal from a tiny cohort, not a retention curve."
50+ user interviews	True, and the strongest asset you have that is not a number.	Nothing — this one is fine.	"50+ interviews where people described this problem unprompted. I can send you the notes."
Quotes on slide 5	Written as what people said they would do, or what they said about the concept, not verbatim from daily users of this build.	That these are paying users' testimonials.	Either label them on the slide ("what early testers told us about the concept") or drop them. See 7.3.
"MVP running today on macOS"	True. It runs on your Mac.	That it is downloadable.	"It runs on my machine; there's no installer yet. That's the month-one deliverable."

7.2 The 26-person cohort: three versions, pick the true one

You need to know, before Monday, exactly how D7 and D30 were measured. There are only three honest possibilities. Find yours and memorise the matching paragraph. If you do not know, use version C — the weakest claim honestly held is worth more than the strongest claim that collapses.

If the measurement was…	The words to use
A. Instrumented (the app logged opens, or you had a dashboard)	"D7 was 22 of 26 and D30 was 19 of 26, from local usage logs on the previous build. It's a 26-person cohort, so I treat it as a signal, not a curve. I'm happy to walk you through the raw data."
B. Self-report (you asked them, or they messaged you)	"I checked in with all 26 by message. 22 told me they'd used it in the first week; 19 said they were still using it at day 30. Self-reported, small cohort — I'd rather give you the method than the percentage."
C. Informal (you know most of them kept using it, no systematic count)	"Honestly: I don't have a rigorous retention number. 26 people tried the previous build; most of them kept coming back and told me so. What I have that's rigorous is 50+ interviews and a product that works. Instrumenting retention is the first thing this round pays for."

WARNING
Two different 19-of-26s — do not let them merge in your head. The deck's "19 of 26 at day 30" is about the previous build that classmates used. Separately, 19 of the 26 people at the hackathon said they would use Evo daily once it was finished. Those are two unrelated facts that happen to share a number. If you say "19 of 26 are using it daily" you have described neither of them, and if he later finds out, it reads as a founder who does not know his own data. Decide now which one you are citing, and cite only that one.

WARNING
If version C is the truth, do not say 85% at all. Say the sentence above and let the number go. He will respect it more than any founder he met this week who quoted a number they could not source. And you will not spend the next four weeks afraid of a diligence request.

7.3 The testimonials on slide 5

You wrote them deliberately to get attention, and they did their job — the deck got you the meeting. But in the room, three quotes attributed to "freelance product designer, Berlin" and "PhD candidate" read as customers. If he asks "can I talk to one of them?", you need a clean answer.

SAY THIS
Those quotes are composites — what people told me they'd do if it existed, and what early testers said about the concept. They're not from paying users. I put them in to make the pain concrete, and I'll relabel them before this goes any further.

GOOD TO KNOW
This one sentence, delivered calmly, converts a liability into a character reference. Founders who correct their own deck in front of an investor are rare, and it is exactly the behaviour Thomas's own writing says he values: "owning evaluation" rather than performing confidence.

7.4 The waitlist, reframed as an asset

"300+ verbal" sounds weak next to a landing page with 300 emails. It is not weak — it is a different asset, and it is arguably a better one at this stage: a list of people who have already heard the pitch and said yes, in person, plus 300 warm relationships you can convert on launch day.

SAY THIS
I don't have a signup list; I have something more useful at this stage. 300+ people have heard me describe this and asked to use it — at hackathons, college tech events, and in conversations with PMs, SDEs, founders'-office people and strategy analysts. When the beta opens, I go back to those 300 personally. At the same time I'm putting up a landing page so the next 300 are measurable.

7.5 What he is actually scoring

Signal	Your honest level	How to move it in the room
Does the founder know their own numbers cold?	Medium — you can quote the deck, but the method is fuzzy.	Decide the method before Monday. Say it once, precisely, then stop.
Is demand real or imagined?	Strong on conversations, unproven on conversion.	Offer the one proof you can produce in a week: a landing page with 50 real emails, or 5 people installing the build on their own machines.
Would users be upset if it disappeared?	Unknown.	Ask your 26 this week. One question: "how annoyed would you be if Evo stopped working tomorrow?" Bring the answers. This is the single fastest traction artefact you can create before Monday.

Signal	Your honest level	How to move it in the room
Can this founder build and ship?	Strong — 16 crates, a working macOS app, a voice pipeline.	Show the terminal. Show the test count. Engineers trust artefacts.

08 The ten questions that decide this

Each question below is written the way he will actually ask it — short, flat, no preamble. Each answer is built to be spoken in under 90 seconds, with the trap named so you can hear it coming.

Q1. "Why does this need to exist as a company? Apple could ship this in a point release."

What he is really asking: Is your value proposition separable from an OS feature?

SAY THIS

Apple could ship a memory feature, and they probably will — a good-enough one, like Spotlight. But the restoration layer is not a feature Apple wants to own, because it requires taking over other vendors' apps: reopening VS Code at the right workspace, Chrome at the right tabs, a terminal at the right directory. Apple will not orchestrate third-party state that way, and they will not do it across Windows. The other half is trust: an OS vendor cannot ask a user to let it watch everything, because the same company ships the advertising and the cloud. We can. Our whole architecture is the promise.

WARNING

The trap is arguing Apple cannot build it. They can. The defensible claim is that Apple will build a narrow, opt-in, first-party version — and that the wedge is cross-app orchestration plus cross-OS continuity, which is against Apple's interest and outside Microsoft's reach.

EVIDENCE

Historical base rate, used carefully: Apple absorbed clipboard managers into Spotlight and Sherlocked Watson, but 1Password, Alfred, Raycast, BetterTouchTool and Hazel survived by being deeper than the native version. The pattern is that Apple takes the shallow version of a category, not the deep one.

Q2. "This is a great utility. Why is it a venture-scale company and not a $5M ARR Mac app?"

What he is really asking: Can you describe the second and third acts without hand-waving?

SAY THIS

Because the unit of value isn't the app, it's the accumulated work memory. Three expansions, in order. First, the prosumer wedge at $108 a year: developers, designers, founders — the 6.1 million US computer and mathematical professionals are the beachhead, not the market. Second, cross-device: the same body of work continues on your phone and your Windows machine, which is where the subscription becomes non-optional and where the OS vendors structurally can't follow. Third, the context layer for agents: every agent that acts on your behalf needs to know what you were doing and what state the work is in. We'd be the API for that, and we'd be paid per seat by teams, not per user by individuals. The Mac app is how we earn the right to build the layer.

WARNING

The trap is answering with TAM. "1 billion knowledge workers" is not an answer; it is a deflection. Answer with the sequence, the price at each stage, and the one metric that unlocks the next stage.

EVIDENCE
Comparables that actually support the sequence: Granola went from a $4.25M seed in 2023 to a $125M Series C at a $1.5B valuation in March 2026 by turning a Mac meeting notetaker into enterprise context infrastructure. Raycast went from a launcher to a $30M Series B and a Windows/iOS platform. Both started narrower than Evo's current pitch.

Q3. "OpenAI shipped Computer History in August. Microsoft has Recall. What's left for you?"

What he is really asking: Are you differentiated against a free feature shipped by the two most important companies in the category?

SAY THIS
Both of them observe; neither restores. Computer History builds a searchable timeline and turns repeated workflows into skills — it doesn't reopen your workspace. Recall screenshots a Windows machine and lets you search it. Neither classifies by body of work, neither reopens third-party app state, and neither works across macOS and Windows. The observation layer is commoditising — that's fine, I don't need to own it. I need to own classification and restoration, which is where the switching cost accumulates. And there's a trust asymmetry: OpenAI processes your activity on its servers to build those memories; the memory files it writes back are unencrypted Markdown in your home directory. I don't think the users who care about this will hand it to them.

WARNING
The trap is dismissing them. Do not say "OpenAI is not a threat." Say precisely what they do not do, and concede the part they do better (distribution, model quality).

EVIDENCE
Verified from OpenAI's own documentation: Computer History is opt-in, macOS, Pro/Business/Enterprise, uses accessibility events rather than screenshots, keeps raw events up to 48 hours on-device before server-side summarisation, deletes the raw events afterwards, and stores the resulting memories as plain-text Markdown under the Codex memories directory. It does not restore applications.

Q4. "Why won't Raycast, Notion, or a browser just add this?"

What he is really asking: Is your category defensible against well-funded adjacent products with distribution?

SAY THIS
Raycast is the one I watch. They have the right user, paid distribution, and in v2.0 they added agents, memory and screen awareness. But their model is command-driven and app-container-driven: they launch things. They don't hold the state of a body of work across apps and days, and they've shown no interest in restoring somebody else's windows. Notion and the browsers are worse positioned — they only see their own surface, and the work doesn't live in one surface. The reason nobody has done this is that it requires a local daemon watching the OS, a classification engine, and a restoration executor. That's three hard things, and the first two are boring. Boring is a moat when it's three years of corpus.

WARNING
The trap is claiming no one is close. Someone is always close. Concede Raycast's distribution, then differentiate on state ownership.

Q5. "Rewind raised a lot of money and died. Why are you different?"

What he is really asking: Have you internalised the failure of the closest precedent — a precedent NEA itself funded?

SAY THIS

Rewind recorded everything and restored nothing. It was a search box over a surveillance archive: screenshots of your whole screen, all day, and the value was "find that thing you saw." That product had two problems it could never solve: the privacy posture was indefensible for mainstream users, and the search result was never the work — it was a pointer to the work. We record metadata, not pixels: app, window, file, tab, document identity. We restore the workspace, not replay a video of it. And the retention loop is different: Rewind's value was flat over time — a bigger archive — while ours compounds, because the classification gets better the longer you use it.

WARNING

The trap is criticising Rewind's team or strategy. NEA backed them. Attack the product thesis, never the people, and never the round.

EVIDENCE

Public record: Rewind raised $10M at a $75M valuation in 2022 led by a16z; NEA led a $12M round at a $350M valuation in 2023; the company pivoted to the Limitless pendant in April 2024; Meta acquired it in December 2025 and the Mac app was permanently disabled on 19 December 2025. Total raised: more than $33M.

Q6. "You have 26 users. How do I know any of this retains?"

What he is really asking: Is there any evidence that the product survives contact with a real workday?

SAY THIS

You don't, yet — and I'd rather say that than pretend a 26-person cohort is a curve. What I have is three things. A 26-person cohort where 19 were still using it at day 30 on the previous build. A product that solves a problem people already pay to solve badly — session managers, tab managers, and manual rituals. And a mechanism that gets better with tenure, which means retention should improve, not decay, as classification sharpens. What I don't have is a 1,000-user instrumented cohort. That is precisely what this round buys: public launch, instrumentation from day one, and a published weekly retention number.

WARNING

The trap is defending the 26-person number as if it were statistically meaningful. He knows it isn't. What he is testing is whether you know it isn't.

EVIDENCE

The honest bar for a prosumer desktop product at pre-seed, per the research in your own repository: a D30 of 15–25% with a flattening curve is strong; below 10% raises questions. Your 19/26 (73%) is far above that — which is exactly why the method matters more than the number.

Q7. "Accessibility, screen recording, input monitoring. Enterprises will never allow this. Consumers will be creeped out."

What he is really asking: Is the permission model a fatal distribution constraint?

SAY THIS
Two answers. For consumers: we ask for less than Rewind did. Accessibility and, for some surfaces, screen recording — no microphone unless you turn on voice, no screenshots stored, no audio, metadata only, with per-app exclusions and a pause that actually pauses. Every permission is asked at the moment it is needed, with a screen that says what it does and what it does not do. For enterprises: the wedge is individuals, not IT. Developers install tools without procurement all the time. When we go to teams, the pitch changes from 'let us watch your people' to 'let your people keep their own memory, with admin policy, audit logs, and nothing leaving the device.' Local-first is the enterprise argument, not just the consumer one.

WARNING
The trap is pretending friction doesn't exist. Sequoia added recurring re-authorisation prompts for screen recording; Tahoe added warnings for background apps. Every one of those is a tax you will pay. Say so, and say how you measure the drop-off.

EVIDENCE
macOS 15 Sequoia introduced periodic re-authorisation for Screen Recording (weekly in beta, relaxed after developer backlash). macOS 26 Tahoe added warnings for background apps and tighter menu-bar controls. Plan for it: an onboarding funnel instrumented for permission abandonment is a diligence asset, not a chore.

Q8. "Local-first means no data moat. You can't train on it, you can't build network effects, and the model vendors will catch up."

What he is really asking: Is privacy a strategy or a constraint you are dressing up as a strategy?

SAY THIS
Privacy is not the moat; it's the licence to operate. The moat is that the classification model is personal: it learns your bodies of work from your evidence, on your machine. That's not a dataset I can pool, and it's also not one a competitor can copy — they'd have to start from zero with the same user. What is poolable is the shared structure: what a "code review" looks like across users, which app pairs co-occur, what a handoff pattern is. That's the part I can learn across the fleet, with consent, without ever moving a user's content. So the moat is: per-user compounding state plus fleet-level structural priors. Neither requires me to hold your documents.

WARNING
The trap is claiming a data moat you don't have. He will ask "what data do you have that I don't?" The honest answer is: 26 users' worth, and a design that makes the data structurally unavailable to anyone else.

EVIDENCE
Comparables that survived without a pooled data moat: 1Password ($620M raised, $6.8B valuation, >$400M ARR by 2025, majority enterprise), Obsidian (bootstrapped, ~1.5M MAU, estimated $2–25M ARR), Tailscale. The pattern is trust plus workflow lock-in plus paid layers — not aggregate data.

Q9. "You're a solo founder in India, you're not a heavy engineer, and this is a crowded space. Why you?"

What he is really asking: Is this founder going to be alive and credible in three years, in a market where execution speed decides?

SAY THIS

Fair question, and I'll answer the three parts separately. Solo: I'm not solo — Manavv runs market, pricing and channels, and he's been in the room for every pricing and positioning decision. India: our first users are US and European developers, the product is a download, and the cost base lets me ship for 18 months on $1.5M where a Bay Area team would need $4M. Not a heavy engineer: true. I designed the architecture, I wrote the engine with AI assistance, and I can show you 1,087 passing tests and a hard regression gate — so the question isn't whether I type every line, it's whether the thing works. And on crowded: the crowding is in observation. Nobody is in restoration. I've been in this problem for a year, I've talked to 300+ people about it, and I'll still be in it in three years, because I use it every day.

WARNING

The trap is getting defensive about the coding question. Do not say "I'm learning to code" and do not say "AI writes everything." Say what is true: you designed it, you ship it, and the artefact is testable. Then show the artefact.

EVIDENCE

The strongest reframe available to you: at pre-seed, the underwriting question is founder-market fit and speed, and your build velocity is visible in 138,500 lines of Rust across 16 crates with a documented build log. Very few 22-year-olds have that artefact. Lead with the artefact, not the apology.

Q10. "$1.5M at $12M post. Why that number, and what does it buy?"

What he is really asking: Are you pricing this rationally, and do you know what the money is for?

SAY THIS

Eighteen months of runway at a cost base that is mostly two people and infrastructure. It funds four hires — two engineers, two growth — a macOS and Windows public beta, 5,000 activated users, encrypted sync and the iPhone capture surface, and Pro going live in month three. The milestones are the ones on the last slide: 5,000 activated by week six, 1,500 paying by month five, 100K users and roughly $1M ARR run-rate by month 12. The cap is deliberately below the median for a $1–2.5M pre-seed, because I'd rather give up less and hit the seed on the numbers than price the round for a headline.

WARNING

The trap is defensiveness about the valuation. If he pushes back, do not immediately move. Ask what would justify a different number, then decide. Section 11 has the negotiation table.

EVIDENCE

Benchmark: median post-money SAFE cap for pre-seed rounds of $1M–$2.5M was around $15M in this period; median pre-seed pre-money valuation around $7.7M (Q3 2025). A $12M post on $1.5M raised is a 12.5% dilution — moderate for pre-seed and defensible. Your number is not greedy; say so once, without apology.

09 The technical interrogation

This is where you have an advantage most founders do not: he is an engineer who will understand your answers, and he will respect an honest limitation more than a confident hand-wave. Do not try to sound like a distributed-systems researcher. Sound like the person who built the thing and knows where it breaks.

T1. "Walk me through the pipeline. What happens between a click and a restored workspace?"

Five stages, and they're separate crates so each one is testable in isolation. Observation turns OS events — app focus, window title, document identity, browser tab, file open — into a normalised event stream. Artifact resolves identity: the same document opened twice is one artifact, not two events. Engagement is where dwell and interaction become evidence that this artifact mattered. Threads and workspace form bodies of work by clustering that evidence. Restoration turns a body of work into a plan — which app, which resource, in what order — and execution runs it natively through the OS. The important design decision is that identity is separate from membership: the same URL can belong to two different works, because the evidence around it differs.

> **WARNING**
> Do not claim the pipeline is finished or that every stage is equally mature. The honest status is that observation, ledger and restoration are solid, and classification is the part that still needs the most work. Say that.

T2. "How do you evaluate classification? What's your ground truth?"

Two layers. A labelled corpus of real work sessions — hand-labelled bodies of work with the evidence that belongs to each — and a regression gate that runs on every commit and fails the build if classification regresses on that corpus. The second layer is a shadow gate: replay real captured logs through the current engine and compare the output to the last accepted output, so I can see drift on data I didn't label. The thing I'd want to build next is a per-user evaluation: the user's corrections — merge, split, rename — are labelled data by definition, and they're the only ground truth that scales.

> **WARNING**
> The landmine is claiming a benchmark. You have a regression harness, not a leaderboard. If he asks for a number, give the pass rate on your corpus and the size of it, and say what it does not cover.

T3. "What happens when it gets it wrong?"

It will get it wrong, and the design assumption is that the user corrects it and the correction is durable. Merge two works, split one, rename one, exclude a resource — each of those is stored as an explicit assertion that outranks inferred evidence. The failure mode I care about is silent wrongness: the engine confidently putting a client's work into another client's workspace. That's why the surfacing is conservative — better to show two works and let you pick than to merge them and be wrong.

> **WARNING**
> Do not say "it learns automatically and gets better." He will ask how, and "it just does" ends the conversation. Describe the mechanism: explicit assertions outrank inferred evidence, and the assertions are the training signal.

T4. "Restoration is the hard part. What breaks?"

Three classes. Apps with no scripting interface — Electron apps vary wildly, and some provide nothing beyond a window. Browser tabs are a per-browser adapter problem: Chrome, Safari, Arc all expose different state. And terminal working directories, which are recoverable for some shells and not others. My approach is a capability tier per app: full restore, partial restore with a best-effort path, or honest failure that tells the user what it could not reopen. I would rather be right about 80% of apps and honest about

the other 20% than claim 100% and break trust on the first morning.

> **WARNING**
> The landmine is claiming universal restoration. If you say "any app," he will name an app on the call — likely something obscure — and you will lose. Say the tiers.

T5. "What's actually running on-device, and what does it cost in RAM?"

The voice path is local: a wake-word model on ONNX Runtime, Whisper base.en for transcription, and a local embedding model for intent matching. No cloud call in the path. The classification engine is not a large model — it's deterministic evidence scoring plus local embeddings, which is deliberate: a 3B-parameter model running continuously on a laptop is a battery and thermal problem, and it would make the product worse. The daemon is idle-cheap by design; expensive work is triggered, not continuous.

> **WARNING**
> Do not overstate model sophistication. "We use a local LLM for everything" invites questions about latency, memory and battery that you do not want on a 30-minute call. The honest and stronger answer is that most of the intelligence is deterministic and the models are used where they earn their cost.

T6. "Why Rust? And why a daemon instead of an app?"

Rust because the core is a long-running local process touching the filesystem, the window server and SQLite concurrently, and I wanted memory safety without a garbage collector pause in the middle of a restore. A daemon because observation has to outlive the UI: the app can be closed, the engine still needs to know what happened. Splitting them also means the engine is testable without a GUI, which is why the test suite can run in CI.

> **WARNING**
> The landmine is saying "I chose Rust because it's fast" — that's a language-fanboy answer. The real answer is about correctness boundaries and observability, which is what he cares about.

T7. "Where does the data live, and is it encrypted?"

Local SQLite with FTS5 for the ledger and the index, under the app's storage root. Activity metadata, not screen recordings and not keystrokes. Today the protection is the OS: FileVault plus the app sandbox boundary. Per-record encryption with a key in the Keychain is on the roadmap and is a requirement before sync ships — I'm not going to build cross-device sync on an unencrypted local store.

> **WARNING**
> Do not claim end-to-end encryption today. If you do, he will ask which key, where it lives, and what the threat model is. "FileVault plus sandbox; per-record encryption before sync" is a credible, honest answer.

T8. "You're asking for Accessibility. That's the same permission keyloggers use. How is this not spyware?"

Four distinctions. We use Accessibility to read what is on screen and which window is focused , not Input Monitoring, which is the permission that intercepts raw keystrokes — we never ask for it. We don't capture screenshots or audio by default. We store metadata, not content. And every capture surface has an explicit pause, per-app exclusion, and a delete-everything control, with no server in the loop. The product has to be defensible to a security researcher, not just to a user, because one bad write-up ends a local-first company.

> **WARNING**
> The landmine is minimising it. "Everyone asks for Accessibility" is exactly what a spyware vendor says. Name the threat model and the boundaries unprompted.

T9. "What's the storage and performance profile at 100,000 users? What's per-user growth per day?"

Per user, the ledger is event metadata — kilobytes to low megabytes per day depending on activity, and the index is incremental. The daemon does not recompute the whole workspace on every event; the projection is a pure function with a daemon-level cache, and workspace derivation is updated incrementally. At 100K users, the infrastructure cost is the sync service and the Pro entitlement check, not the observation — because observation never leaves the device. That's an unusual and useful property: our marginal cost per user is close to zero until they turn on sync.

> **WARNING**
> Do not give a precise storage number you have not measured. Give the order of magnitude and say you would instrument it during the beta.

T10. "What does Windows actually cost you?"

Two problems, not one. Capture is tractable: UI Automation and Win32 give you window and document identity, and the event model maps onto the same observation contracts. Restoration is the expensive half, because every app exposes a different automation surface and the conventions are different. My estimate is that the capture layer is weeks and the restoration layer is months, per app family. That's why the plan is macOS first with Windows public beta in the first six weeks after the round — the capture path, not full restore.

> **WARNING**
> If you have not written a line of Windows code, say so. "I've scoped it but not built it" is a fine answer at pre-seed; a confident timeline you can't defend is not.

T11. "How would encrypted sync work without you being able to read the data?"

The design constraint is that the server never sees plaintext. Each device holds a key derived from the user's account, the sync payload is encrypted client-side, and the server stores opaque blobs plus a version vector. Conflict resolution is the hard part — two devices editing the same body of work — and the answer is that the ledger is append-only and the workspace projection is deterministic, so conflicts resolve by merging evidence rather than by last-write-wins on a document. I haven't built it. It's month two to five, and it's why the round is $1.5M and not $500K.

> **WARNING**
> Do not claim CRDT expertise you don't have. The append-only ledger argument is true and sufficient; inventing a sync architecture on the call is how founders get caught.

T12. "I saw a reverse-engineering folder in your repo. What is that?"

Competitive teardown for design research. I inspected the shipped binaries of adjacent Mac apps — a time tracker, a session manager, a couple of AI note tools — to understand how they model projects, what they store, and where their model breaks. It's the same thing I'd do with public documentation if they had any. No code was copied; the Evo engine is a separate design and the notes are about product decisions, not implementation.

WARNING

This is a real risk if framed badly. Never say "I reverse-engineered competitors to copy them." Frame it as product research on public binaries, and if he pushes, offer to remove the folder from the repo before a code review. Better: move it out of the repo before Monday.

10 Every number in the deck, graded

Print this page. Learn the grade column. The rule for the whole meeting: a number you can source is an asset; a number you cannot source is a debt that comes due in diligence.

Number in the deck	Where it comes from	Grade	If challenged, say
25 min 26 s to return to interrupted work	Mark, González & Harris, CHI 2005. 24 information workers, 700+ hours observed, 77% same-day resumption, 2.26 tasks in between.	A — primary	"That's the published figure. The popular '23 minutes' is a different number from a later interview; the paper says 25:26."
~1,200 app toggles per workday	HBR, Aug 2022 — Murty, Dadlani & Das, using Soroco work-graph data: 137 users, 20 teams, 3 Fortune 500 companies, 5 weeks.	B — vendor study	"It's a vendor study published by HBR — 137 users, not a population estimate. Directionally right, specific number is soft."
Interrupted every 2 minutes	Microsoft Work Trend Index 2025. M365 telemetry, 31 markets, excluding EU and education; top 20% of users by ping volume; 275/day.	B+ — vendor, with a narrower base	"Microsoft's telemetry, and it's the top quintile of ping volume — I should have said that on the slide."
300+ organic waitlist sign-ups	Verbal conversations, no landing page.	D — not a waitlist	See 7.4. Reframe as conversations; name the gap.
26 MVP testers	People who used the previous build.	B — true, but not this build	"Previous build, not the current engine."
19 of 26 active at day 30 (73%)	Previous build, method unclear.	C — depends on method	See 7.2. Use the matching version.
D7: 22 of 26 (85%)	Same cohort.	C — depends on method	"A signal from a 26-person cohort, not a retention curve."
50+ user interviews	Your own conversations, mostly from Reddit and in person.	A — true	"50+ interviews, and I can send the notes."
6.1M US computer & mathematical professionals	BLS Current Population Survey, 2024.	A — government	"BLS CPS 2024. The broader management and professional category is 70.7M; I use the narrow one as the beachhead."
70.7M management, professional & related	BLS CPS 2024.	A — government	Fine as stated.
~1B knowledge workers worldwide	Gartner estimate, widely quoted.	C — analyst estimate	"Gartner's number; I use it only as the ceiling, not as a plan."
2.5B active Apple devices	Apple, Q1 FY2026 earnings.	A — company disclosure	"Apple's own number. Note it's all devices, not Macs."
1.4B+ active Windows devices	Microsoft, company statements.	B — company, approximate	Fine.
40% of enterprise apps ship task-specific agents by end-2026 (from <5% in 2025)	Gartner prediction.	B — analyst forecast	"It's a Gartner forecast, not a measurement. It's there to show direction."
$108/year Pro	Your pricing decision.	A — your choice	Defend the arithmetic in section 11.
5,000 activated by week 6	Your plan.	D — target, not evidence	"That's a milestone, not a claim. It's the number this round is buying."
1,500 paying by month 5 · 100K users · ~$1M ARR by month 12	Your plan.	D — targets	Present as milestones with the conversion assumption behind them: 100K users at 9% paying at $108 is ~$970K.
$1.5M at $12M post, 18 months	Your ask.	A — decision	Section 11.

Number in the deck	Where it comes from	Grade	If challenged, say
16 crates · ~138,500 lines of Rust · 1,087 tests passing	Your repository.	A — verifiable	Have the terminal open. This is your best number.

WARNING

The two numbers that will hurt you are 300+ waitlist and the day-30 retention, because both invite a follow-up you cannot yet satisfy. Fix them verbally before he asks. The two numbers that will help you most are 25:26 and 1,087 tests, because one is unimpeachable and the other is evidence of craft.

11 The ask, the terms, and the room to move

11.1 What you are selling

Term	Your position	What it means in practice
Raise	$1.5M	Enough for 18 months at a two-person-plus-four-hire cost base in India and the US.
Instrument	Post-money SAFE	No priced round, no board seat, no preferred stock. Standard for pre-seed: SAFEs were ~90% of pre-seed rounds in Carta's Q1 2025 data.
Cap	$12M post-money	A $1.5M cheque buys 12.5% at the cap. Median post-money cap for $1M–$2.5M pre-seed rounds was around $15M; median pre-seed pre-money valuation around $7.7M in Q3 2025.
Runway	18 months	Seed from month 12, so four months of buffer before you need it.
Use of funds	60% team · 30% launches and growth · 10% infra, security audit, legal	Two engineers and two growth hires; macOS and Windows public beta; a security audit before sync.

11.2 The arithmetic he will do in his head

- Dilution: $1.5M ÷ $12M post = 12.5% . He will think: reasonable for pre-seed, leaves room for a seed round and an A.
- Ownership for NEA: if NEA takes the whole $1.5M at 12.5%, a 12% stake needs a $125M exit to return 10% of a $1B fund — which is why a single $1.5M pre-seed cheque barely moves NEA's needle, and why the real question for him is whether this can become a $50M+ position later.
- Runway math: $1.5M over 18 months is ~$83K/month. Two engineers + two growth + infra + legal + audit. In the Bay Area that is impossible; in Delhi NCR it is comfortable. He may ask where the team sits — answer plainly, and make the cost advantage a feature, not an apology.
- What a seed round needs: $1–3M ARR, or $1M ARR with strong growth, per NEA's own public framing. Your plan says ~$1M ARR run-rate at month 12. That is the number the seed depends on, and he knows it.

11.3 Four things he can plausibly offer — decide your answer now

What he says	What it means	Your prepared response
"We'd like to lead the $1.5M."	Best case. Goes to partner meeting, then diligence.	"That's what I'm hoping for. What would you need from me to make the case?"
"We'd put in $500K–$1M as part of the round."	Real interest, smaller cheque, they want others to price it.	"That works if it helps you get conviction. I'm talking to a small number of others; I'd rather have NEA in the round than maximise the cheque."

What he says	What it means	Your prepared response
"This is a bit early for us — come back at seed."	A pass with a door left open. Common at NEA's size.	"I understand. What specifically would you need to see? I'll send it to you when it exists, whether or not you're in this round."
"We could do a smaller pre-seed cheque now."	An option, not a commitment. Sometimes a scout or partner-level cheque.	"What size, and on what instrument? I'm open to it if it doesn't complicate the seed."

11.4 Negotiation: three numbers, decided in advance

Decide these before the call, write them down, and do not renegotiate with yourself while he is looking at you.

Number	What it is	Your value (decide now)	Why
Target	The cap you want	$12M post	Defensible against the $15M median for this round size; leaves room to move.
Walk-away	The lowest cap you would accept from a strong lead	$10M post (15% dilution)	Below this, the seed round gets harder because your early investors' ownership becomes a negotiation problem.
Alternative	What you offer instead of a lower cap	A smaller round at the same cap — $1M at $12M (8.3%)	Protects the cap and still funds 12 months. You can raise the rest from angels.

DO NOT
Do not negotiate valuation on this call. If he raises the cap, say: "I've thought about it and I'm happy to talk terms if we get to a term sheet. Today I'd rather spend the time on the product." Then move on.

NOTE
Legal terms you should be able to name but not debate: post-money cap, discount rate, MFN, pro-rata rights, information rights, no board seat at pre-seed. Before you sign anything, pay a startup lawyer for one hour. It is the cheapest insurance in this entire process.

12 Your story, told without flinching

He is not hiring you for a job. He is deciding whether to attach his name to you inside a firm where his judgement is the product. The story has to answer one unspoken question: will this person still be building this in three years, when it is harder than it is today?

12.1 The 60-second origin, in your own voice

> **SAY THIS**
> I'm a computer science graduate from Delhi. I was working on multiple projects at once and every morning started the same way: twenty-six windows, and twenty minutes of trying to remember which one mattered. I didn't think of it as a product at first — I thought of it as a personal failure. Then I started asking people, and they described the same thing in different words. A designer said she'd stopped shutting her laptop because she didn't want to lose three client setups. A backend engineer said his problem wasn't writing code, it was remembering what he was writing it for. That's when I decided this was the thing I wanted to build, and I've been building it since.

12.2 The three sentences that must be true

Claim	Evidence you can point to	How to say it without bragging
I build things that work.	16 crates, ~138,500 lines of Rust, 1,087 tests passing, a macOS app that runs a local voice pipeline, and a build log with dated verification runs.	"The repo is public. You can read the build log — every round is dated with what changed and how it was verified."
I understand the problem better than the competition.	50+ interviews, 300+ conversations, and a product decision record in the repo's own product docs.	"I've been in this problem for a year and I've written down what I learned. I can send you the notes."
I will still be here.	You built the thing you personally needed, and you use it every day; the roadmap runs 12 months past this round.	"I use it every morning. That's the honest answer to why I'll still be doing this."

12.3 The questions about you that are actually about risk

If he asks…	He is worried about…	Answer
"Are you doing this full time?"	Split attention, a job, a degree, visa plans.	"Full time. Evo is the only thing I'm building."
"Where are you based?"	Timezone, US presence, hiring.	"Delhi NCR. The first users are US and European developers, it's a download, and my cost base means 18 months of runway instead of 8."
"Is Manavv full time?"	Whether the co-founder is real.	"Yes — he owns market, pricing and channels, and he's been in every positioning decision."
"Why not go to YC?"	Whether anyone else has validated you.	"I'd consider it, but I'd rather take capital from someone who has a thesis about this category than a generic programme. That's why I wrote to Lila."
"Who else is investing?"	Whether there is a real round or a fantasy.	Tell the truth about conversations, not commitments. If there are none: "I'm at the start of the process. You're one of three people I've approached."

12.4 The thing you must not apologise for

You are a young founder in India building an ambitious consumer-grade product with AI-assisted development. Every one of those facts is a strength in this specific meeting, and none of them should be volunteered as a confession:

- Age — nobody who has shipped 138K lines needs to mention age. If he asks, answer and move on.
- Geography — it is a cost advantage and a market insight (India's developer population is enormous). Say it as a fact about runway, never as an excuse.
- AI-assisted coding — the artefact is the answer. "I designed the architecture and I ship it. Here is the test suite."
- Solo-founder risk — you are two. Name Manavv early and specifically, so the 'solo founder' frame never takes hold.

13 The do-not-say list

Fourteen sentences that cost founders pre-seed rounds, each with the version that works. Read this twice on the morning of the call.

Never say	Say instead
1. "It's vibe coded."	"I designed the architecture and built it with AI assistance. The engine is 16 crates with a hard regression gate — you can read the tests."
2. "No one has really used it yet."	"The current engine is on my machine. 26 people used the previous build; the alpha cohort starts when the installer ships."
3. "We have no competition."	"The observation layer is crowded — OpenAI, Microsoft, Raycast. Nobody restores. That's the gap."
4. "OpenAI probably won't build restoration."	"OpenAI is optimising for a general assistant; restoration requires per-app orchestration and taking over other vendors' windows. They may try. I'm building the thing that's hard for them to prioritise."
5. "We have 300 waitlist sign-ups."	"300+ conversations and a verbal waitlist. The landing page goes up in week one."
6. "Our retention is 73% at day 30."	"19 of 26 were still using the previous build at day 30. Small cohort, self-reported / logged — here's the method."
7. "I'm not really technical."	"I'm not a distributed-systems engineer. I designed this system, I ship it, and I know exactly where it breaks."
8. "We just need to ship and then we'll figure out monetisation."	"Free core, $108 Pro from month three, and the conversion assumption is 9% of activated users by month five."
9. "The valuation is firm at $12M."	"$12M post is where I'm raising. If we get to a term sheet I'm happy to talk about structure."
10. "Everyone will use this."	"The beachhead is developers, designers and founders with parallel projects — 6.1M people in the US alone. The rest is expansion, not the plan."
11. "Trust me, it works."	"Don't trust me — watch it. And here's the part that doesn't work yet."
12. "I haven't thought about that."	"I haven't — let me think out loud." Then actually think. A founder who can reason in real time is more impressive than one who has a memorised answer.
13. "Our competitor is bad."	"They solved a different problem. Rewind recorded everything; the value was search. Ours is restoration."
14. "Can you introduce us to a16z/Sequoia?"	Never on a first call. If the relationship develops, ask for intros to customers or operators, not to other investors.

WARNING
The two that matter most: never inflate a number, and never claim a capability you have not demonstrated. Everything else on this list is recoverable in the next sentence.

14 Questions you ask him

Asking good questions does three things: it buys you information, it signals that you are evaluating him too, and it gives him language to use internally. Ask four or five, not fifteen. Write them on a card.

#	The question	Why it works	What the answer tells you
1	"What would make this a yes for you, specifically?"	Forces him to name the bar instead of implying one.	Whether the bar is traction, team, market or thesis fit. If he can't articulate it, he hasn't decided to champion you.
2	"What's the strongest reason you'd pass?"	Invites the objection you can then address — or at least know about.	His real ranking of risks. Whatever he says first is what the memo will say.
3	"Who else would need to be convinced, and what do they care about?"	Teaches you the internal audience.	Which partner owns AI at NEA, whether it's a Monday partnership decision, and how long it takes.
4	"Given NEA's stage focus, is a $1.5M pre-seed the right shape for you — or would you rather see this at seed?"	Shows you understand his fund's economics better than most founders.	Whether he is fishing for a bigger round, a smaller option, or a pass.
5	"Which portfolio company is closest to this, and what did they get right early?"	Invites him to teach, which associates love.	The internal comparable he'll use — Anyscale, Factory, Namespace, Wispr, Rewind. If he says Rewind, you know the ghost in the room.
6	"What have you seen work in the last 12 months for prosumer AI products?"	Gets you free market intel from someone who sees dozens of deals.	Whether he believes prosumer can be venture-scale, and which comps he'd accept.
7	"How do you personally like to work with founders in the first year?"	Signals you're selecting him, not just pitching.	Whether he is an operator-investor or a memo-writer; how much help to expect.
8	"What would you want to see in the next four weeks that would make this easy?"	Converts the call into a to-do list.	The exact artefact to build. Then build it before he asks again.

DO NOT

Do not ask: "So what do you think?" (puts him on the spot and invites a polite no), "What's your valuation benchmark?" (prices before value), or "Can you intro us to other funds?" (tells him you want his network, not his money).

15 The 24 hours after the call

15.1 The same-day note (send within 3 hours)

Short. No attachment. One specific reference to something he said, one thing you promised, one next step. Write it in your own voice — he will compare it to how you speak.

> Thomas — thank you for the time. The point you made about [specific thing he said] is the one I've been thinking about since we hung up, and it's changed how I'm thinking about [specific decision].
>
> As promised: [the one artefact he asked for]. I'll send it by [day].
>
> If it's useful, I'd welcome the chance to show you the [next milestone] when it's ready — whether or not this round is the right fit.
>
> — Bhavit
>
> — Template — replace the brackets with real content

15.2 The five-document data room (build it in 48 hours)

Document	What it contains	Why he needs it
1. One-page metrics sheet	Cohort definition, D7/D30 with method, interviews, conversations, activation definition, and the number you do not have.	It is the thing he will forward to a partner. Make it one page.
2. Demo recording	Three minutes, screen-recorded, no voice-over except yours, showing the restore end-to-end.	He will watch it again before the partner meeting, probably with someone else.
3. Architecture one-pager	The crate diagram, the pipeline, where data lives, what leaves the device (nothing).	This is the document that survives a technical partner's read.
4. Deck v2	The current deck with the traction slide corrected and the testimonial labels fixed.	It shows you act on feedback within a week. That is the whole signal.
5. Founder one-pagers	Half a page each: what you've built, what you own, why you're doing this.	It is what gets pasted into the memo's team section.

15.3 Cadence, if he goes quiet

Day	Action	Tone
Day 0	Thank-you note + the artefact you promised.	Warm, specific, short.
Day 3–4	Send the thing you said you'd send, even if it is imperfect.	No apology, no essay.
Day 10	One-line check-in with a new fact (a user number, a shipped feature), not a nudge.	"Thought you'd want to see this" — never "just following up."
Day 21	Ask a direct question: "Is this still live for you, or should I come back at seed?"	Gives him an easy exit and you a clear answer.
Day 45+	Quarterly update, one page, whether or not he replied.	Build the relationship independent of the round.

15.4 What not to send

- A 40-slide deck. He asked for none; the 11 you sent is already at the limit.
- A Notion link that requires a login. PDF or nothing.
- A wall of text explaining your market. If it needs explaining, the one-pager is wrong.
- A revised valuation or terms in writing before he asks. It reads as panic.
- Anything you would not want forwarded to a partner unedited. Assume everything is forwarded.

16 If he says no — and if he says yes

16.1 The three kinds of no

What he says	What it means	What to do in the room
"It's too early for us."	Stage mismatch, not quality. NEA's seed cheques start around $1M and its attention is on companies with revenue.	"What would 'not too early' look like — a number of users, a retention curve, revenue?" Write it down. Send it when it's true.
"It's not a fit for the fund."	The category or the check size doesn't work for NEA. Rarely reversible.	"Understood. Is there someone in your network for whom this is more on-thesis? I'd rather have a good referral than a polite maybe."
"I don't believe the wedge expands."	A thesis disagreement. The most useful no you can get.	"What would change your mind?" Then send exactly that, in 60 days, with data.

16.2 If the answer is yes, what happens next

1. He writes a memo. Expect him to ask for the five documents and two or three customer references — which is why you need five real users who will take a call.
2. Partner meeting (Monday). He presents; you are not in the room. The quality of his memo is the quality of your meeting. This is why the one-sentence pitch matters more than any slide.
3. Diligence: 2–4 weeks. Code review by a technical partner or an outside expert, reference calls, market work, sometimes a call with a portfolio founder in the space.
4. Legal and close: 1–2 weeks. SAFE, cap table, IP assignment, incorporation. If any of these are missing, it is the most common cause of a deal slipping a month.
5. Total: 4–8 weeks on NEA's own typical timeline; faster if the case is uncontested and pre-referred.

> **WARNING**
> The three things that kill pre-seed deals between the partner meeting and close: (1) an unassigned IP or co-founder equity question, (2) a founder who disappears for a week during diligence, (3) a traction number that changes when someone else measures it. All three are preventable this week.

16.3 Run the process, don't wait for it

One interested associate is not a round. In the same week, write to five more people with the same specificity you used with Lila — a piece they wrote, a company they backed, a problem you can tie to their thesis. Not a mass email. Five individual emails, each referencing something real.

> **GOOD TO KNOW**
> If Thomas asks "who else are you talking to?", the best answer is the truth told calmly: "Three people at funds with a thesis about this. None of them have said yes." That is credible. "We have a lot of interest" from a founder with 26 users is not.

17 Appendix

17.1 The claim audit: what is safe to say, and what is not

Claim	Status	Use it?
Evo is a 16-crate Rust system that runs on macOS today	Verified in the repository	Yes
~138,500 lines of Rust; 1,087 tests passing at the last recorded run	Verified in the build log — re-run before the call and quote the fresh number	Yes
Local voice pipeline with wake word and local Whisper	Implemented; requires local model provisioning	Yes, with "when the models are provisioned"
300+ waitlist	Verbal only	Only as conversations
26 MVP testers / 19 at day 30	Previous build, method dependent	With the method stated
50+ interviews	True	Yes
NEA led Rewind's $12M round at $350M	Public record	Only if he raises it — and never as a positive
OpenAI Computer History launched Aug 2026, no restoration	Verified from OpenAI documentation	Yes
Rewind Mac app killed 19 Dec 2025	Public record	Yes
Granola raised $125M at $1.5B in Mar 2026	TechCrunch, Bloomberg	Yes, as a category comp
Apple has not shipped activity restoration	No evidence found; not proof of absence	Say "I haven't seen one", not "Apple doesn't"
"Nobody restores context"	True as of this research, but Hansel/Recall/Cove are close on parts	Say "nobody restores the whole workspace"

17.2 The eight numbers to know cold

#	Number	What it is
1	25 min 26 s	Published time to resume an interrupted task (CHI 2005)
2	2.26	Other tasks completed before resumption — the tax is not one number, it's a queue
3	50+	Interviews where people described the problem unprompted
4	26 / 22 / 19	Previous-build cohort at install / day 7 / day 30
5	16 crates	The engineering artefact — the thing that proves this is not a wrapper
6	$108	Annual Pro price; the unit economics of the whole model
7	$12M post	The cap; 12.5% dilution for $1.5M
8	18 months	Runway; seed from month 12

17.3 The 90-second version, if you only get 90 seconds

> **SAY THIS**
> Every interruption costs about 25 minutes of re-entry. The tools that exist search your history; none of them put you back in the work. Evo watches work locally, groups it into bodies of work, and rebuilds the entire workspace when you say "Hey Evo, continue the investor deck." It's 16 Rust crates, it runs on my Mac today, and 26 people used the previous build. I'm raising $1.5M to ship the public beta and prove retention. Can I show you the restore?

17.4 The night before

- Run the demo three times. Once cold, once after a reboot, once with the screen shared to a friend on a call.
- Run the test suite and screenshot the output.
- Write the four numbers you will say out loud on a sticky note: 25:26, 26/19, 16, $12M.
- Read section 13 (do-not-say) once. Then close this book.
- Sleep. A tired founder with a live demo beats a wired founder with a perfect script.

17.5 Sources for the external claims in this book

NEA team pages for Thomas Joshi and Lila Tretikov; NEA's blog posts "The Neolab Wild West" (17 Jun 2026), "Namespace: CI/CD is Dead, Agents Need Computers" (23 Mar 2026) and "From Algorithms to Atoms, Part II" (23 Jul 2026); NEA's portfolio page for Rewind; Fortune, "NEA: the VC world's best-kept secret" (7 Nov 2011); TechCrunch, "The perfect pitch: this NEA partner says every founder should answer these 5 questions" (19 Jul 2025); TechCrunch on Granola's $125M Series C (25 Mar 2026) and Wispr's $280M Series B (17 Aug 2026); the Economic Times and Fortune reports on Rewind's 2023 round; OpenAI's Computer History documentation; Mark, González & Harris, CHI 2005; Mark, Gudith & Klocke, CHI 2008; Microsoft Work Trend Index 2025; HBR, "How much time and energy do we waste toggling between applications?" (Aug 2022); BLS CPS 2024 occupational tables; Carta State of Pre-Seed data as reported for 2025–2026.

Where a source is an aggregator, an estimate, or a vendor's own research, the text says so. Nothing in this book should be repeated to an investor as fact unless the grade in section 10 is A or B.